

The World Development Indicators is an open database from the World Bank, an international financial institution focused on “global development and the fight against poverty” (Ott). Using the International Monetary Fund’s (IMF) General Data Dissemination System, they provide reliable, comprehensive, and pertinent data directly from over 200 countries/economies. The data is sourced via the World Bank from censuses, surveys, field researchers, and their external partners, and the data published has been validated under the Data Quality Assessment Framework. It is regarded as “the most current and accurate global development data available” (Ott).

The data is standardized to the yearly level and is most granularly represented at the country level with aggregates based on region. As a country level indicator, each data point is actually representative of an aggregate of hundreds if not thousands of individual data points, representative of a country’s population. As lots of these indicators are summary statistics, we need to allow some time for the development of each indicator, so we are using data from the year 2022. The indicators themselves are split into six main areas: Poverty and Inequality, People, Environment, Economy, States and Markets, and Global Links (WDI Website). While there are over 1500 fields in this expansive database, our indicators of interest are Internet Use, Youth Literacy, Adult Literacy, and GDP per Capita.

Internet Use seeks to measure the percentage of a country’s population who have used the internet for any use in the past 3 months. The precise measure is the penetration rate of internet access: the share of households with access to the internet within a country. The indicator seeks to capture an aggregation of subscription, access, and use, and is sourced from household/survey data or directly from internet providers. The data quality traditionally varies from country to country, but the multi-national Partnership on Measuring ICT for Development has sought to fix these discrepancies over the past 20 years.

Youth Literacy seeks to measure the percentage of adolescents and young adults aged 15-24 who have basic reading, writing, and arithmetic skills. Literacy data is gathered from the UNESCO Institute for Statistics and is, again, an aggregation of survey data and national censuses. Literacy is typically very hard to measure; there are potential sampling biases (individuals that aren’t measured are excluded), much of the data is self-reported without any testing frameworks, and the definition of literacy differs from country to country. However, it is agreed upon that literacy rates do a good job of capturing educational attainment. Likewise, Adult Literacy is calculated from the same dataset but captures a larger population than strictly Youths, namely, ages 15 and up.

Finally, GDP per Capita captures the nominal Gross Domestic Product, the sum of all final goods and services produced by a country in terms of the current day value of the US dollar. Generally, GDP per Capita is the most widely used and trusted indicator for a country’s economic performance, compiled in accordance with international standards.

In general, development data can be tough to compare across countries: does every country measure GDP the same way? Does every country use the same standards for literacy? What

level of data accuracy does each country adhere to? However, with the WDI, the data is standardized using the General Data Dissemination System via the International Monetary Fund and is assessed under the Data Quality Assessment Framework via the World Bank. This amounts to less data than has been collected but ensures the existence of verifiable, high quality, standardized data. Even if the collection techniques might slightly differ from country to country, the data is comparable with each other, and should be a good measure of what it is supposed to be representing.